Part II: The Olivet Discourse, Read in Its Own Century

Chapter 7: Matthew 24, approached rather than assumed

I want to be honest about what I expected when I opened this chapter of the investigation, because what I expected is part of the evidence about me.

I expected to be confirmed.

I had been reading Matthew 24 as a first-century passage for years. I had a method now, and the method had already cost me something in Acts, which I took as proof that it worked. So I came to the Olivet Discourse assuming that a careful pass would tidy up my reasons and leave the conclusion where it was.

That is not quite what happened. It took longer, it went sideways twice, and the thing that actually moved was not the conclusion but my sense of where the difficulty had been coming from.

TWO QUESTIONS I HAD BEEN ASKING AS ONE

The first useful thing was noticing that I had been arguing about two different things and calling them one.

There is the question of what a verse says. And there is the question of where we are standing relative to what it de-

scribes. Those are separable. A verse can have a perfectly clear meaning while my location relative to its fulfillment remains unsettled, and treating them as a single question had let me use certainty about the first as though it were certainty about the second.

That distinction sounds obvious written down. It was not obvious while I was doing it.

STARTING AT VERSE 1 INSTEAD OF VERSE 14

The second useful thing was refusing to start where the argument usually starts.

Almost every conversation I had ever had about Matthew 24 began at verse 14, the good news proclaimed and then the end comes. That is where my own position had lived. So I made myself begin at verse 1, with the disciples pointing at the buildings.

> **THE TEMPLE IN THE FIRST CENTURY**
>
> The temple in Jerusalem was not simply a large religious building. It was the center of Israel's covenant life, the place where sacrifice was offered and where God's presence was understood to dwell among His people. It was destroyed by Roman armies in the year 70, an event that ended the sacrificial system as it had operated for centuries. A first-century Jewish audience being told this building would be thrown down was not receiving an abstract prophecy.

The temple is the catalyst. Yeshua says not one stone will be left on another, and the disciples come to Him privately with a question that has parts, and the parts are worth reading slowly, because verse 3 is where the passage tells you what it thinks it is about.

They ask when *these things* will be. They ask for the sign of His coming. And they ask about the end of the age.

Age, not world. The Greek is αἰών (*aiōn*, age), not κόσμος (*kosmos*, world). A reader with an English Bible that says "the end of the world" has been handed a conclusion before reaching the discourse. That is not a translator conspiring; *aiōn* is genuinely hard to render in one English word. But the effect on the reader is real.

HOW CLAIMS ARE LABELED

- **EXPLICIT TEXT** — the passage says it
- **STRONG CUMULATIVE INFERENCE** — many independent lines converge
- **PROBABLE RECONSTRUCTION** — my best account of how the pieces fit
- **HISTORICAL OBSERVATION** — something about the world, checkable
- **HYPOTHESIS** — under test, not established
- **OPEN QUESTION** — deliberately not claimed

Aiōn at 24:3 is explicit text. What ends when an age ends is not, and I am not going to let the first carry the second.

THE WORD MY WHOLE POSITION DEPENDED ON

Then verse 14, the verse I had been quoting for years.

> This good news of the kingdom will be proclaimed in all the world as a testimony to all nations, and then the end will come

The phrase behind "all the world" is ἡ οἰκουμένη (*hē oikoumenē*, the inhabited world). I had been reading it as the inhabited earth, every continent, everybody. And I had been using it to argue that the commission was accomplished.

So I went to find where else the word appears, and the two places I found are not obscure.

Luke 2:1 says a decree went out from Caesar Augustus that all the *oikoumenē* should be registered. Caesar did not tax the Americas. He taxed the empire.

Acts 11:28 says a famine would come over all the *oikoumenē*, and Luke then reports it happening in the days of Claudius, which is a first-century event with a scope a first-century reader could recognize. The CJB renders both of these "throughout the Empire," which is a translator making the same observation.

WHAT *OIKOUMENĒ* CAN CARRY AT MATTHEW 24:14

CONTRADICTS → PERMITS → SUPPORTS → REQUIRES

Oikoumenē at Luke 2:1 and Acts 11:28 SUPPORTS a bounded, Roman-world sense for the word. It does not reach REQUIRES at Matthew 24:14, because a word's range is not a rule about every occurrence.

I want that brake to stay on, because this is exactly where I could have manufactured a dictionary. Finding two occurrences that suit me is not the same as establishing a meaning.

PAUL SAYS A JOB IS FINISHED WHILE MILLIONS HAVE NOT HEARD HIM

The thing that genuinely surprised me was not lexical. It was Paul.

> from Jerusalem and all the way around to Illyricum I have fulfilled the ministry of the gospel of Christ (Romans 15:19, ESV)

> But now, since I no longer have any room for work in these regions (Romans 15:23, ESV)

I have to slow down on the first of those, because I nearly used it carelessly.

"Fulfilled the ministry of" is several English words standing in for one Greek one, and the noun among them is supplied by the translator. What Paul fills up is the good news itself.

The ESV adds “the ministry of” to make the English read naturally; the CJB goes the other way and renders the same clause “I have fully proclaimed the Good News of the Messiah”; the RVR1960 keeps the filling image and says *todo lo he llenado del evangelio de Cristo*. All three are defensible. None of them licenses me to build an argument on the English word *fulfilled* as though Paul had reached for a technical term.

> **ROMANS 15:19 — WHAT PAUL FILLS UP**
>
> πεπληρωκέναι τὸ εὐαγγέλιον τοῦ Χριστοῦ · *peplērōkenai to euangelion tou Christou*
>
> πεπληρωκέναι (*peplērōkenai*) is a perfect infinitive of πληρόω (*plēroō*), to fill up or bring to completion. Its object is τὸ εὐαγγέλιον (*to euangelion*), the good news, not a ministry of it.
>
> What it establishes: Paul regards something as standing completed. What it does **not** establish: which sense of completion he means. That is settled by what he says next, not by the verb.

And what he says next is much plainer than any word study, which is the part that actually moved me. Paul describes his assignment across an enormous territory as brought to completion, and in the following breath says he has no room left to work there. Written by a man in a region containing enormous numbers of people who had never heard him speak.

That was the moment my confidence in my own instincts about scope weakened, and it weakened in a direction I did

not expect. It did not tell me what *oikoumenē* means in Matthew 24:14. It told me that a first-century apostle could describe a mission as completed in a region using a standard I do not share and would not have guessed.

Which means my sense of what "all" must mean is not a neutral instrument.

> **ROMANS 15:19 AND 23 — WHAT THEY SHOW AND WHAT THEY DO NOT**
>
> The evidence of Romans 15:19 and 23 **SUPPORTS** the conclusion that a first-century apostle could regard a mission territory as complete without every individual in it having heard him preach.
>
> They do **not** establish anything about the scope of *oikoumenē* at Matthew 24:14. And Paul is describing his own pioneering assignment, not the fulfillment of a prophecy. Those are different questions, and this book does not get to slide between them.

THIS GENERATION, TESTED WHERE IT SHOULD BE TESTED

Then the phrase everything eventually turns on. I did not settle it here, and I will not pretend I did.

What I did was check how Matthew uses it elsewhere: 11:16, 12:41 and 42, 12:45, and 23:36. That last one matters most and gets its own chapter later, because it sits one chapter before the discourse and uses nearly the same construction.

And restoring the chain from Matthew 23 into 24 changed the feel of the passage considerably. The chapter break is a

later convenience. Yeshua is speaking about Jerusalem, then about the temple, then He walks out of it and the disciples point at the stones.

THREE HYPOTHESES, NONE ADOPTED

I came out of this with three live possibilities and no verdict, which is not a dodge but an honest description of where the evidence had gotten to.

A. The discourse addresses first-century events, and its language should be read accordingly.

B. The discourse telescopes, moving between near and far events in a way that resists a single timeline.

B2. Something in it belongs to a later interval, which is the possibility that eventually becomes the millennium question and the little season.

I marked B2 *permits at most, not yet argued*, and I want that label preserved rather than tidied, because it is the earliest appearance of the question this whole book eventually fails to resolve.

A CORRECTION AGAINST MYSELF, ON THE RECORD

One more thing happened here that had nothing to do with Matthew.

I had been carrying an objection to first-century readings that went: if the millennium began then, where did all the nations at the end of it come from? I had treated that as a problem in the text.

Revelation 20:7 and 8 simply says the nations are there. They exist. John does not explain their origin and does not appear to think it needs explaining.

The problem was not in Revelation. It was a premise I had brought and then found missing, and I had blamed the text for not containing it.

That is the second time in this investigation that a difficulty turned out to be mine, and it is not the last.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. What a verse says and where we stand relative to it are two questions, and I had been treating them as one. Matthew 24 begins with a temple and a question about the end of an *age*, not a *world*. The word carrying my strongest argument, *oikoumenē*, is used of Caesar's empire and a first-century famine, which supports a bounded sense without requiring it. And Paul can call a regional mission fulfilled while enormous numbers there have never heard him, which tells me my instincts about the word "all" are not neutral. Three hypotheses are open. None is adopted.

THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES. The passage is not yet decided, but the objections I thought were fatal to a first-century reading are starting to look like objections to something else. The largest one is next: what about the Son of Man coming on the clouds?

Chapter 8: clouds

This is the objection I expected to lose on.

Whatever else Matthew 24 says, verse 30 has the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven with power and great glory, and every instinct I had said that this is the one image that cannot be relocated into the first century without cheating.

So I went at it directly, and the first thing I did was ask where the image comes from, because by this point in the investigation I had a rule about that.

WHERE THE PICTURE COMES FROM

Matthew 24:30 is not inventing its vocabulary. It is quoting.

> I saw in the night visions, and behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man, and he came to the Ancient of Days and was presented before him. And to him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom (Daniel 7:13-14)

Read the direction of travel.

The figure does not descend from the sky to the ground. He comes **to the Ancient of Days**. He is brought near, presented, and given dominion. The scene is a throne room, and what happens in it is enthronement and vindication.

I had been carrying a picture of Daniel 7 in my head that had the movement running the other way, and I had never checked, because I had never needed to.

> **DANIEL 7:13 — WHICH WAY THE FIGURE TRAVELS**
>
> The direction in Daniel 7:13 is explicit text. It [REQUIRES] that the source image is a presentation before a throne rather than a descent to earth.
>
> What it does **not** establish is that Matthew 24:30 must therefore carry only that sense. Matthew is quoting Daniel, not being confined to Daniel. That is a real inference gap and I am not going to walk across it quietly.

THE CLOUD VOCABULARY, ASSEMBLED

Then I gathered the cloud language across the Tanakh, and it is more consistent than I anticipated.

Clouds are where God's presence is: the pillar leading Israel out of Egypt, the cloud filling the tabernacle. Clouds are where deliverance comes from in Psalm 18, where He bows the heavens and comes down with darkness under His feet, in a poem describing a rescue that happened. Nahum has Him with clouds as the dust of His feet.

And then the one that did the most work.

> Behold, the LORD is riding on a swift cloud and comes to Egypt (Isaiah 19:1)

That is a cloud-coming. It is stated as a coming of the LORD. And what it describes is a judgment on Egypt carried out in history, through ordinary historical means, without anyone claiming that God physically descended over the Nile on a visible cloud.

I want to be careful about what that gives me. It gives me a precedent for cloud-coming language describing divine judgment executed within history. It does not, by itself, tell me what Matthew 24:30 is describing.

> **STORM AND CLOUD AS THE LANGUAGE OF JUDGMENT**
>
> Isaiah 19 belongs to a sequence of oracles against surrounding nations. Ancient Near Eastern prophetic literature regularly describes a deity's action against a kingdom in language of storm, cloud, and cosmic disturbance, while the events referred to are military and political. Isaiah is not unusual in this; recognizing the convention is not explaining it away.

SPOKEN TO HIS OWN JUDGES

The strongest single datum in this chapter is not in Matthew 24 at all.

At His trial, under direct questioning, Yeshua answers by combining Daniel 7 with Psalm 110, and He says it to the men judging Him:

> **you** will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power and coming on the clouds of heaven (Matthew 26:64; Mark 14:62)

That is a second-person address to a specific set of people standing in a specific room.

Here is where I had to stop myself, and I want it visible, because it is the exact error this book keeps accusing other systems of.

Two questions are easy to run together here, and I ran them together at first.

The address is settled. **You** is second-person plural, spoken to identifiable men standing in a specific room. Nothing in this chapter softens that, and I am not going to let it be softened later on if it becomes inconvenient.

What *kind* of seeing the saying requires is a separate question, and I had no business closing it here. Reaching for a recognition sense *because* the plain one is awkward would be redefinition-under-pressure, and that is exactly the move I refuse to accept from a futurist reading when the pressure runs the other way. But treating ordinary eyesight as established — on the grounds that it is the first sense an English reader reaches for — is the same error wearing different clothes, and it is the one I nearly made. The verb has not been tested in these pages. Until it is, neither sense is settled.

The translations will not let me pretend otherwise. They diverge exactly where the timing lives:

> **from now on** you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power (Matthew 26:64, ESV)

> **one day** you will see the Son of Man… (Matthew 26:64, CJB)

From now on and *one day* are not the same claim. The RVR1960 goes with the first, *desde ahora veréis*. I am not going to resolve that here either.

So the verse stays open, and it is a difficulty for anyone, including me. What it establishes is that specific men — His own judges — were told they would see something. What it does not establish is what seeing it would have required of them.

HOW CLAIMS ARE LABELED

- **EXPLICIT TEXT** — Daniel 7's direction of travel; the second-person address at Matthew 26:64
- **STRONG CUMULATIVE INFERENCE** — cloud language across the Tanakh regularly describes divine action within history
- **PROBABLE RECONSTRUCTION** — Matthew 24:30 draws on that convention
- **HISTORICAL OBSERVATION** — Isaiah 19's Egypt judgment occurred through ordinary historical means
- **HYPOTHESIS** — that the discourse's cloud-coming refers to a first-century vindication
- **OPEN QUESTION** — what "you will see" required of the men who heard it

A RULE THAT COMES OUT OF THIS AND NEVER LEAVES

Something general came out of this chapter that governs the rest of the book, and it is worth stating on its own.

Before assigning a modern literal meaning to an image in Revelation or the Prophets, find where Scripture used that image first.

Not because the earlier use automatically decides the later one. It does not, and a later chapter will show a case where it emphatically does not. But because a reader who skips that step is not choosing between the ancient meaning and a

modern one. He is choosing the modern one without knowing there was an alternative.

LITERAL IS NOT THE SAME AS PHYSICALISTIC

One more distinction, small and load-bearing.

When I say a passage may be using conventional prophetic imagery, I am not saying nothing happened. Isaiah 19 describes something that happened. Egypt was judged. The imagery is not a way of saying the event was unreal.

A symbol can describe an entirely real event. Treating *symbolic* and *actual* as opposites is a modern reflex, and it has done as much damage to careful reading as wooden literalism has.

ONE TRANSLATION CHOICE WORTH SEEING

The CJB renders γῆ (*gē*, land, earth) as "the Land" at both Matthew 24:30 and Revelation 1:7, where other translations have "earth."

I am not citing that as proof. A translator's choice is a translator's judgment. I am citing it because the difference between *all the tribes of the earth* and *all the families of the Land* is enormous, and an English reader with one Bible on the table will never know a choice was made.

That question gets its own chapter, three chapters from here.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. The cloud-coming's source passage is Daniel 7, and in Daniel the Son of Man travels **to** the Ancient of Days and is enthroned, not down to earth. Cloud language across the Tanakh regularly describes divine action executed within history, with Isaiah 19's judgment on Egypt as the clearest control. None of that decides Matthew 24:30, and the second-person "you will see" at the trial remains a genuine difficulty which I have refused to solve by redefining the verb.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** If the cloud imagery has a Tanakh source that changes how it reads, what about the rest of the cosmic collapse in the same passage? The sun darkened, the moon failing, the stars falling.

Chapter 9: cosmic signs, and a rule named

The sun darkened. The moon not giving its light. The stars falling from heaven. The powers of the heavens shaken.

If the cloud-coming was the objection I expected to lose on, this is the one I expected to be laughed at over. You cannot relocate the collapse of the sky into the first century. Nothing like that happened in the year 70.

So I did what the previous chapter taught me to do, and went looking for where the language comes from. What I found was not one precedent. It was three, about three different kingdoms, in the same vocabulary.

THREE KINGDOMS, ONE SET OF IMAGES

Isaiah 13 is an oracle about Babylon. The stars of the heavens will not give their light, the sun will be dark at its rising, the moon will not shed its light, the heavens will tremble and the earth will be shaken out of its place.

And then, in the same oracle, Isaiah names the mechanism: the Medes. A specific people, arriving with specific weapons.

Isaiah 34 is about Edom. All the host of heaven shall rot away, the skies roll up like a scroll, all their host shall fall as leaves fall from the vine.

Ezekiel 32 is about Egypt. I will cover the heavens and make their stars dark, I will cover the sun with a cloud and the moon shall not give its light.

Three separate kingdoms. Three judgments that took place in history, through armies. One shared vocabulary of the sky coming apart.

> **COSMIC COLLAPSE IN THE PROPHETS — THREE KINGDOMS**
>
> That this vocabulary is used of historical judgments on kingdoms is explicit text, three times, with a named military mechanism in one of them.
>
> It [REQUIRES] that cosmic-collapse language is at minimum *available* for historical judgment. It [SUPPORTS] reading Matthew 24:29 within that convention. It does not reach [REQUIRES] for that reading, because a convention is a range, not a rule.

AND REVELATION IS QUOTING ISAIAH 34 NEARLY VERBATIM

Then something that stopped me for a while.

Revelation 6:12 through 14 has the sun becoming black, the moon becoming like blood, the stars falling to earth, and the sky rolling up like a scroll.

That is Isaiah 34:4, with the same stars and the same rolled scroll.

I had spent years hearing Revelation 6 described as a description of the physical end of the cosmos, and I had never once been told that its imagery is quoted from an oracle about Edom.

That is not an argument that Revelation 6 means what Isaiah 34 meant. Chapter 8's brake applies here too. But it changed what I thought I was looking at, and it made me suspicious of how confidently that passage had been explained to me.

THE APOSTLES DID THIS THEMSELVES

The datum that carried the most weight is not in the Prophets. It is in Acts.

At Pentecost, Peter stands up and explains what is happening by quoting Joel: the sun turned to darkness and the moon to blood before the great and magnificent day of the LORD.

Nobody present reported the sun going out. Peter applies cosmic prophetic language to an event he and his hearers were standing inside.

> **PENTECOST (SHAVUOT)**
>
> Pentecost, or Shavuot, is one of the pilgrimage festivals of Israel, held fifty days after Passover. Acts 2 places a large and varied crowd of Jews and proselytes in Jerusalem for it, which is why the account emphasizes the many places they had come from.

So the question is no longer whether anyone ever used this language for events that were not the physical end of the sky. An apostle did it, in a sermon, in the New Testament, about a day his audience had lived through.

THE RULE, AND ITS LIMITING CLAUSE

At this point I named a rule I had been using informally for two chapters.

Intertextual Priority. Where a text uses imagery Scripture has used before, the earlier usage has first claim on how the image is read.

And immediately, in the same breath, the clause that keeps it from becoming a machine:

Precedent constrains interpretation. It does not mechanically determine it.

I put the limit next to the rule on purpose. A rule like this without its brake becomes a way of settling every hard passage by pointing at an older one, which is just proof-texting with more footnotes.

A GUARDRAIL I NEARLY NEEDED

Genesis 37 has Joseph dreaming of the sun, the moon, and eleven stars bowing to him, and his father immediately reads the sun and moon as himself and Joseph's mother.

Celestial bodies standing for covenant persons. That is genuinely there, and it is genuinely relevant.

It is also exactly where I could have built a new dictionary: stars equals leaders, therefore falling stars equals falling rulers, therefore every passage. One dream is not a lexicon. I kept it as a real datum, with an explicit caution against turning it into a rule, and that caution is doing more work in this book than the datum is.

> **EZEKIEL**
>
> A priest taken to Babylon in the exile of the sixth century before Yeshua, who prophesied to the exiled community there. His book is one of the largest sources of the imagery Revelation later uses, which is why he keeps appearing in this investigation long before we reach Revelation itself.

SIDEBAR: STARS, THE DRAGON, AND THE CROSS

A side branch opened here that is worth a page and not a chapter, and it contains a correction against me.

Revelation 1:20 gives an explicit key: the seven stars are the angels of the seven assemblies. Where a text supplies its own

decoding, that decoding outranks my guesses. So stars can stand for angelic beings, on John's own authority.

That made a familiar sentence available: a third of the angels rebelled. I had been carrying it as something Scripture states.

It is not. It is an inference, assembled from Revelation 12:4's stars swept down by the dragon's tail plus a set of assumptions about what that pictures. The inference may well be right. But I had been holding it as text, and it is not text, so I moved it into the inference box where it belongs.

The same branch produced a much bigger caution. Isaiah 14, the passage most often read as the fall of Satan, states its own referent at verse 4: this is a taunt against the king of Babylon.

The satanic reading is later typology. It may be legitimate typology. But the stated referent is a human king, and I had never noticed, because nobody had ever pointed at verse 4 while quoting verse 12.

That is the clearest example in this book so far of the difference between what a passage says and the tradition of reading it that arrives with it.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Cosmic-collapse language is used in Scripture of historical judgments on Babylon, Edom and Egypt, once with the invading army named. Revelation 6 quotes Isaiah 34's version of it. And at Pentecost an apostle applies the same kind of language to a day his hearers were living through. That does not decide Matthew 24:29, but it removes the assumption that such language can only describe the physical end of the sky. Intertextual Priority is now a named rule, with its brake attached: precedent constrains, it does not determine.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** If the darkening and the falling stars have a prophetic convention behind them, then the next line has to be faced. He sends out His angels with a great trumpet, and they gather the elect from the four winds.

Chapter 10: the gathering, and the second costly concession

> And he will send out his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather his elect from the four winds, from one end of heaven to the other (Matthew 24:31)

This is the verse where a first-century reading feels most strained, and I want to walk through what I did with it carefully, because I got something wrong here that was not caught until Part VII.

WHERE THE GATHERING LANGUAGE COMES FROM

Following the rule from the last chapter, I went looking for the source, and the source is not thin.

> If your outcasts are in the uttermost parts of heaven, from there the LORD your God will gather you (Deuteronomy 30:4)

> he will assemble the banished of Israel, and gather the dispersed of Judah from the four corners of the earth (Isaiah 11:12)

> Fear not, for I am with you; I will bring your offspring from the east, and from the west I will gather you (Isaiah 43:5)

> for I have spread you abroad as the four winds of the heavens (Zechariah 2:6)

Four winds, verbatim, in Zechariah. Uttermost parts of heaven, in Deuteronomy, which is the phrase Matthew 24:31 nearly reproduces.

And then the trumpet:

> And in that day a great trumpet will be blown, and those who are lost in the land of Assyria and those driven out to the land of Egypt will come and worship the LORD (Isaiah 27:13)

A great trumpet, and a gathering of scattered Israel. Matthew 24:31 has both, in that order.

> **MATTHEW 24:31 AND ISRAEL'S REGATHERING VOCABULARY**
>
> The verbal overlap with Deuteronomy 30:4, Zechariah 2:6 and Isaiah 27:13 is explicit text, and it SUPPORTS reading Matthew 24:31 against Israel's regathering tradition rather than as a novel image.
>
> It does **not** establish what event Matthew is describing. Shared vocabulary establishes a shared *word*. It does not establish a shared *event*, and I will have to be reminded of that later, harshly.

A WORD THAT WOULD HAVE SOLVED MY PROBLEM

Now the concession, and it is the second one this method has extracted from me.

The Greek at 24:31 is ἄγγελος (*angelos*, messenger), and *angelos* means messenger. It does not automatically mean a heavenly being. Matthew himself uses it of a man: at 11:10, quoting Malachi about John the Baptist, *behold, I send my messenger before your face*, and the word there is *angelos*.

That opened a reading I badly wanted. If the *angeloi* of 24:31 are human messengers, then the gathering of the elect could be the apostolic mission, carried out by people, in the first century, and one of the hardest verses in the discourse would dissolve.

I sat with that for a while, because it was extremely convenient.

Then I looked at how Matthew uses the specific construction. Not the bare noun, but the phrase *his angels*, sent by the Son of Man. Matthew 13:41 has the same formula and the same gathering language, and there the *angeloi* are plainly heavenly.

So I let the convenient reading go.

> **THE *ANGELOI* OF 24:31 — MOST PROBABLY HEAVENLY, NOT MISSIONARIES**
>
> The *angeloi* of Matthew 24:31 are most probably heavenly messengers, not human missionaries. The lexical possibility of a human sense is real, but Matthew's own usage of the *his angels* formula points the other way, and I am not entitled to select the meaning that rescues my position.

I want to say plainly why that is here. Not because it is a large finding. Because *we do not pick the meaning that saves the theory* is the only rule in this book that would be worth anything if the rest of it turned out wrong.

And it should be said that the concession costs the first-century case almost nothing. That case does not need the gathering to be human missionaries and never rested there. A reading that has to be propped up by the most convenient available lexical option was not standing on much to begin with.

THE MISTAKE I MADE WHILE DOING THAT

I have to flag something in the paragraph above, because a later chapter takes it apart.

I said Matthew 13:41 has *the same formula and the same gathering language*. The formula claim is correct: 13:41 has the Son of Man sending out *his angels*, in near-identical construction.

The gathering-verb claim, which I made at this point and believed for a long time, **is false.** Matthew 13:41 uses συλλέγω (*syllegō*), to collect. Matthew 24:31 uses ἐπισυνάγω (*episynagō*), to gather together. They are different verbs.

I am leaving the error where it happened rather than quietly repairing it, because Part VII is where the investigation catches it, and what the correction then produced is one of the best things in the book. Chasing the actual verb turned up Matthew's only other use of *episynagō*, at 23:37, where Yeshua laments over Jerusalem: *how often would I have gathered your children together*. One chapter before the discourse. And it points away from the reading I prefer.

For now, the argument in this chapter stands on the sending formula, which is genuine, and not on a shared verb, which is not.

ONE CORRECTION THAT IS NOT A GREEK WORD

While I am here: παρουσία (*parousia*), the word usually translated "coming" or "presence," does not appear at Matthew 24:31. It appears at 24:3, 24:27, 24:37 and 24:39. It brackets this pericope; it is not inside it.

I state that because I have seen the mistake made, have nearly made it myself, and because an argument that quietly relocates a word into the verse that needs it is not an argument.

THE HARDEST TEST, NAMED IN ADVANCE

I closed this part of the investigation by writing down what would eventually have to be reconciled, so that I could not pretend later that I had not seen it coming.

Isaiah 27's great trumpet. Matthew 24:31's gathering. 1 Corinthians 15:52's last trumpet and the dead raised imperishable. 1 Thessalonians 4:16's trumpet of God and the dead in Messiah rising. And Revelation 20's first resurrection.

Those have to be fitted together **without protective exceptions**. And one more thing, which became a working rule:

The elaborateness of an exception is itself evidence. If a reading requires four special provisions to survive, the provisions are telling me something about the reading.

That test is not passed in this chapter. It is not passed in this Part. It is where Part VII eventually goes, and it does not go well for several things I believed at this point.

ONE TRUMPET, OR SEVERAL?

Isaiah 27, Matthew 24, 1 Corinthians 15, 1 Thessalonians 4 and Revelation 20 all involve a trumpet and a gathering or a raising. Whether they describe one event, several, or a shared convention applied to different events is not settled here and is not settled for a long time.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Matthew 24:31's gathering is built from Israel's regathering language: Deuteronomy 30:4's uttermost parts, Zechariah 2:6's four winds, Isaiah 27:13's great trumpet. The *angeloi* are most probably heavenly, and I gave up the human-messenger reading even though it would have solved the verse for me. The concession costs the first-century case nothing, which is part of why it was safe to make honestly.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** If the gathering is drawn from Israel's own restoration vocabulary, then the phrase immediately before it needs the same treatment. All the tribes of the earth will mourn. Which earth, and whose tribes?

Chapter 11: tribes of the land

> Then all the tribes of the earth will mourn (Matthew 24:30)

Every translation I owned said earth. All the tribes of the earth. Which sounds like everyone, everywhere, and reads naturally as the whole human race watching something happen in the sky.

Then I looked at the Greek and found a word I had already met.

TWO WORDS, BOTH WITH A HISTORY

The word behind "earth" is γῆ (*gē*). It is the ordinary word for land, ground, soil, territory, country. It can mean the whole earth. It can also mean *this land*, in the way a person in a country says "the land" and everyone knows which one.

The word behind "tribes" is φυλαί (*phylai*), and in Israel's Scriptures that word has a home. Overwhelmingly it is at work in the vocabulary of Israel's own tribes, and that resonance matters here, especially once the source passage turns out to be Zechariah 12. But the word is not restricted to Israel. It carries a wider ethnic sense as well, and Revelation itself stacks it into expansive formulas alongside tongues and peoples and nations — *every tribe and tongue and people*

and nation at 5:9, and the same four again at 7:9. So *phylai* leans in a direction. It cannot establish the referent on its own.

Two words, side by side, both carrying covenantal-land resonance. That is not proof of anything. It is a reason to look further.

WHERE THE SENTENCE COMES FROM

And the sentence has a source, which I should have expected by now.

> And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy, so that, when they look on me, on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn for him (Zechariah 12:10)

Then Zechariah keeps going, and what he does next is the detail that changed the chapter for me:

> The land shall mourn, each family by itself: the family of the house of David by itself, and their wives by themselves; the family of the house of Nathan by itself… (Zechariah 12:12)

Named families. Specific households in a specific place, mourning one by one.

That is not a picture of every nation on earth reacting simultaneously. It is a picture of a particular community in mourning, listed by name.

AND REVELATION FUSES THE TWO ON PURPOSE

Revelation 1:7 puts the two source passages together in a single verse:

> Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him, even those who pierced him, and all tribes of the earth will wail on account of him

Daniel 7's cloud-coming, and Zechariah 12's piercing and mourning, welded into one sentence. John is not assembling these at random; he is reading them as belonging together.

> **MATTHEW 24:30, REVELATION 1:7 AND ZECHARIAH 12**
>
> That Matthew 24:30 and Revelation 1:7 both draw on Zechariah 12 is explicit in the shared piercing-and-mourning language.
>
> The evidence — Zechariah's named families and the vocabulary's history — [SUPPORTS] a covenantal-land sense for *gē* + *phylai* here.
>
> It does not reach [REQUIRES]. Both words have wider ranges, and the wider sense is available.

THOSE WHO PIERCED HIM

One line in Revelation 1:7 needed handling before it could be used: *even those who pierced him*.

Read narrowly, that would be a small number of individuals at one execution, most of whom would be dead within a generation.

Scripture does not read it that narrowly. Peter at Pentecost tells a crowd *you crucified and killed* (Acts 2:23), addressing people who were not personally holding hammers. Acts 4:27 gathers Herod, Pontius Pilate, Gentiles and the peoples of Israel together as those arrayed against Him.

So the phrase has representative scope, covering both Israelite leadership and Roman authority. That is not a way of widening it until it means everybody. It is the way Acts itself uses the responsibility language.

THE DISCIPLINE THAT KEEPS THIS FROM BECOMING A TRICK

Here is where I had to police myself, and it is the most important paragraph in the chapter.

Having found that *gē* can mean the Land, the temptation is enormous to decide that it now means the Land wherever it helps me.

It does not.

> until heaven and earth pass away, not an iota, not a dot, will pass from the Law (Matthew 5:18)

Same author. Same word. And nobody, including me, reads that as a statement about Judean real estate.

> **THE LAND-SENSE OF *GĒ* AT MATTHEW 24:30 — SUPPORTED, NOT ESTABLISHED**
>
> *Gē* in Matthew 24:30 **PERMITS** a covenantal-land sense, and the Zechariah 12 background **SUPPORTS** it. It is not established, and *gē* does not carry that sense automatically elsewhere. No new dictionary is issued by this chapter.

That restraint is the fourth time in this investigation I have escaped a rigid reading and then had to stop myself from installing a rigid replacement. It eventually gets a name, one chapter from here.

ONE AMBIGUITY I REFUSED TO CLOSE

Zechariah's mourning could be grief, the sorrow of people recognizing what they have done. It could be terror, the dread of people facing judgment.

The passage in Zechariah leans toward grief; a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy sits right beside it. Matthew 24:30's context leans darker. Revelation 1:7's *wail* leans darker still.

I could pick. Picking would tidy the chapter.

I am leaving it open, because the difference between mourning-in-repentance and mourning-in-terror is not a detail, and no evidence I have settles it.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER IS ACTUALLY ABOUT

The lexical work here is real but it is not the finding. The finding is about reading.

I had an English Bible that said *all the tribes of the earth*. That sentence has one obvious meaning, and I had held that meaning for years, and I had never once suspected that a decision had been made on my behalf. The translators were not hiding anything. They chose one legitimate rendering of a word with a range, which is what translators do on every page.

But the effect on me was that a question was closed before I knew it was open.

> **WHAT A TRANSLATION DECIDES FOR ITS READER**
>
> A translation can settle a question for its reader before the reader knows there was a question. This is the strongest argument I have found for working at the level of the source languages, and it arrived from inside the evidence rather than being asserted as a principle at the start.

That is why the rest of this book prints the Greek and the Hebrew where an argument turns on wording. Not to sound

learned. Because otherwise you are trusting my English, and my English, like everyone's, has already decided things.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. *Gē* and *phylai* both carry covenantal-land resonance, and Matthew 24:30's mourning comes from Zechariah 12, where the land mourns family by family, by name. Revelation 1:7 fuses Zechariah 12 with Daniel 7 deliberately. The land-sense is supported and not required, and Matthew 5:18 keeps me from issuing a new dictionary. Whether the mourning is grief or terror is left open.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** Three chapters of source-hunting have loosened images I thought were fixed. Which means the plain temporal statements in the same passage can finally be looked at directly. This generation. And heaven and earth passing away.

Chapter 12: the fig tree, this generation, and heaven and earth

Now the verses everything turns on, which I had been avoiding by working on imagery for three chapters.

THE RULE I SHOULD HAVE HAD FROM THE START

Before any of it, something embarrassingly simple that I had never looked at.

Matthew 24 is addressed to somebody, continuously, in the second person. *Take heed that no one leads* **you** *astray*. **You** *will hear of wars. They will deliver* **you** *up. When* **you** *see the abomination. Pray that* **your** *flight may not be in winter. If anyone says to* **you**. *So also, when* **you** *see all these things.*

Verses 4, 6, 9, 15, 20, 23, 33. The discourse changes mode as it goes — it turns proverbial, it tells parables — but it keeps returning to the second person, including at the points where it makes its largest claims.

FINDING — AUDIENCE CONTINUITY

Matthew 24 addresses the disciples in the second person repeatedly and persistently, including around its major prophetic statements. So if "you" is taken to shift to an entirely different, far-future audience partway through, that shift requires textual argument. A system that needs the shift is not evidence for the shift.

That is not an argument that everything in the discourse happened in the first century. It is a rule about where the burden sits, and it cuts against readings I like as often as against readings I do not.

THE FIG TREE IS NOT A DECODER

I had been taught that the fig tree is Israel, that its budding is the modern State of Israel, and that the generation seeing it is ours.

Luke tells the same parable:

> Look at the fig tree, **and all the trees** (Luke 21:29)

And all the trees.

If the fig tree were a coded reference to one nation, adding all the trees destroys the code. What Luke's version shows is that the parable is about reading signs the way you read a

season. You see buds, you know summer is near. That is the whole point, and it is a point about attentiveness, not botany.

> **LUKE'S "AND ALL THE TREES" AGAINST THE FIG-TREE CODE**
>
> Luke 21:29's *and all the trees* CONTRADICTS the *exclusive* decoder reading — the one in which the fig tree uniquely encodes a single nation, so that its budding is the sign. Adding all the trees removes the uniqueness that code depends on.
>
> Against the weaker claim, that the fig tree carries some representative significance while Luke broadens the illustration, it **strongly counts against** without contradicting. I want that distinction kept. This book is asking readers to tell a contradiction apart from evidence that merely makes a position harder to hold, and I do not get an exemption from my own scale.

THIS GENERATION

> Truly, I say to you, this generation will not pass away until all these things take place (Matthew 24:34)

Four readings are available, and I weighed them all: the contemporaries of Yeshua; the Jewish people as a race or people; the generation that sees the signs, whenever that is; or a general moral type.

The strongest single piece of evidence I found is not in chapter 24. It is one chapter earlier.

> Truly, I say to you, **all these things** will come upon **this generation** (Matthew 23:36)

Same construction. Same two phrases. Spoken by the same person, in the same setting, moments before He leaves the temple and the disciples point at the stones. And in Matthew 23 there is no serious dispute about who "this generation" means, because the verse is the climax of a sustained address to the scribes and Pharisees standing in front of Him.

> **MATTHEW 23:36 AND "THIS GENERATION" AT 24:34**
>
> Matthew 23:36 [SUPPORTS] the contemporaries reading at 24:34, strongly. It does not reach [REQUIRES], because a phrase can be re-used with a different scope, and Matthew 24 has moved outdoors and changed audience from the crowds to the disciples.

AND THE EVIDENCE THAT GOES AGAINST ME

Now the part I would rather leave out.

The CJB renders Matthew 24:34 as "this **people**." Not this generation. A major translation, produced by a scholar working deliberately within a Jewish frame of reference, reading the phrase as the Jewish people rather than the contemporaries of Yeshua.

That is a serious witness adopting the reading my investigation has been moving away from. Two of the three translations I work from take the contemporaries reading; one takes the people reading.

I am not going to explain that away, and I am not going to bury it in a footnote. It sits at full strength, in the body of the

chapter, where a reader who wants to disagree with me can find it.

WHAT THE LAST THREE CHAPTERS ACTUALLY ACCOMPLISHED

Here is the thing I did not expect to be the result of Part II.

All that work on clouds and cosmic signs and gathering language did not prove a first-century reading. Not one of those chapters produced a proof.

What it did was remove objections that had made the plain temporal statement look impossible. And once the impossibility was gone, verse 34 was left saying what it had always been saying, in ordinary words, to people standing in front of Him.

Increasingly, some of the impossibility appeared to have come from me.

AND THEN VERSE 35 REOPENED EVERYTHING

I thought I was finishing. Then the next verse.

> Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away (Matthew 24:35)

The obvious reading is the physical cosmos. But heaven and earth have another life in Scripture that I had not considered.

They are summoned as **witnesses** to covenant. *I call heaven and earth to witness against you today* (Deuteronomy 30:19). *Let me speak these words in their ears and call heaven and earth to witness against them* (Deuteronomy 31:28). *Give ear, O heavens, and I will speak* (Deuteronomy 32:1).

And creation language sits beside covenant establishment in Isaiah 51:15 and 16: the one who stirs the sea, who put His words in your mouth, *stretching out the heavens and laying the foundations of the earth, and saying to Zion, You are my people.*

Then Isaiah 65:20, which complicates everyone's position including mine: inside the promised new heavens and new earth, someone dies at a hundred years old. Death is still present in the new creation passage.

> **FINDING — THE ANTI-REPLACEMENT PRINCIPLE**
>
> I escaped a rigid reading here for the fourth time in this investigation, and for the fourth time I had to stop myself installing a rigid replacement. "Heaven and earth means the old covenant" is at PERMITS on this evidence. It is **not established**, and adopting it would be the same error I had just escaped, wearing my colors.
>
> A fourth possibility also stands: the contrast itself may be the point. Whatever passes, His words do not.

THE OTHER "UNTIL," WHICH HAD BEEN THERE THE WHOLE TIME

Then I noticed something that sent me backward in Matthew rather than forward.

Yeshua had said this before.

> until heaven and earth pass away, not an iota, not a dot, will pass from the Law **until all is accomplished** (Matthew 5:18)

Two untils. Not one. Any reading has to account for both, and their relationship is genuinely undetermined: they may be coterminous, the second may define the first, they may be independent, or the pair may be a merism. I tabled four possibilities rather than silently choosing one.

And the Greek is checkable and nearly identical across the two passages.

> **TWO "UNTILS", SIDE BY SIDE**
>
> Matthew 5:18 · ἕως ἂν πάντα γένηται · *heōs an panta genētai*
>
> Matthew 24:34 · ἕως ἂν πάντα ταῦτα γένηται · *heōs an panta tauta genētai*
>
> They differ by ταῦτα (*tauta*), "these." Both passages also share παρέλθῃ (*parelthē*), "pass away."

> **MATTHEW 5:18 AND 24:34 — A PROMPT, NOT A PROOF**
>
> The near-identity of those constructions **establishes a reason to ask** whether Matthew intends a connection. It does **not** establish the connection. Same author, similar phrase, is a strong prompt and a weak proof.

WHAT "FULFILL" DOES AND DOES NOT MEAN

Matthew 5:17 is where I had to slow down most.

καταλῦσαι (*katalysai*), to abolish or destroy, is explicitly negated. And its object is "the Law **or the Prophets**," which is a conventional way of naming Israel's Scriptures as a whole. So reducing the verse to a question about which regulations Christians must keep has already narrowed it below what was said.

πληρῶσαι (*plērōsai*), to fulfill, I read against Matthew's own prior uses of the verb: 1:22, 2:15, 2:17, 4:14, each time of Scripture reaching an intended realization. The CJB translates it "complete."

MATTHEW 5:17 — THE TWO VERBS

καταλῦσαι · *katalysai* · to abolish, tear down — **explicitly negated**, with "the Law or the Prophets" as its object

πληρῶσαι · *plērōsai* · to fill up, bring to intended realization

What the words establish: Yeshua denies coming to tear down, and affirms bringing to completion.

What they do **not** establish: neither "fulfill means terminate" nor "fulfill means nothing may ever change" is in the verb. Both are imported.

THE RULE THAT HAD TO BE INVENTED HERE

By the end of this, I had a mess, and the mess had a shape.

"Is the Law abolished?" turns out to name at least six things that overlap enormously and are not interchangeable: Torah as instruction, the Mosaic covenant, the Levitical priesthood, the temple, the sacrificial administration, and the moral commandments.

FINDING — THE CATEGORY COLLAPSE TEST

Before answering a question, check whether it names one thing or several things packaged as one. This runs **first**. A malformed question cannot be rescued by good exegesis downstream, and "is the Law abolished?" is at least six distinct things — and more questions than that — wearing one coat.

I did not build that theoretically. I had watched Acts 15 do it, chapters ago, which is the advantage of investigating in sequence rather than by topic.

THE COST, RECORDED RATHER THAN HIDDEN

And now the part that I would remove if I were trying to win.

If "all is accomplished" landed in the first century, then Matthew 5:19 has to mean something afterward. *Whoever relaxes one of the least of these commandments and teaches others to do the same will be called least in the kingdom of heaven.*

The easy exit is to say the verse was transitional, applying only until the accomplishment. That exit is available. It is also exactly the kind of protective exception I refuse to grant a futurist reading when it is under pressure.

So I do not get to grant myself one.

OPEN QUESTION — AN UNRESOLVED COST OF THE POSITION

If the first-century reading of "all is accomplished" is correct, Matthew 5:19 requires an account that this book does not yet have. I record it as a cost of my own position rather than a difficulty for somebody else's.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US. Matthew 24 returns to a second-person address repeatedly, including at its largest claims, so a shift to a far-future audience needs textual argument rather than a system. Luke's *and all the trees* contradicts the *exclusive* fig-tree decoder and strongly counts against softer versions of it. Matthew 23:36's identical construction, one chapter earlier, strongly supports the contemporaries reading of 24:34, while the CJB's "this people" stands against it at full strength. The imagery work of the previous chapters did not prove a first-century reading; it removed objections, and much of the impossibility turned out to be mine. Verse 35 then reopened everything: heaven and earth are covenant witnesses elsewhere, which permits an old-covenant reading and establishes nothing, and Isaiah 65:20 has death inside the new creation. Two rules were born here, Anti-Replacement and the Category Collapse Test, and one cost was recorded against my own position at Matthew 5:19.

> **THE QUESTION THIS LEAVES.** If something was completed and something passed away, then the question can no longer be avoided in the abstract. What specifically does Scripture say changed, and what does it say was retained?